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Retirement's First Few Years

One June, Vicki and I were at a backyard barbecue in Evanston, Illinois. One of the guests had just flown in from New York.

"What do you do in New York?" someone asked her.

She said, "I'm vice-president of marketing and merchandising at Fashion Center."

I turned to our host and raised my eyebrows.

He said, "She sells bras."

SO WHAT DO YOU DO?

America's favorite cocktail-party line is "What do you do?" How we ask and answer can reveal more than ten years with a psychotherapist.

Not so abroad. When foreigners go to a party they typically talk about the party: the music, how the food is presented, the paintings, sculpture, and decorations on the walls. To get to know you, foreigners ask about your last vacation, your children, your favorite restaurants, or where you live. They're much more likely to ask what you do on weekends than what you do on weekdays.